Bangla cop universe is one way to put it. Another is a "double prequel", as Srijit Mukherji says. In his October 19 theatrical release, *Dawshom Awbotaar*, chasing the serial killer (Jisshu Sengupta) are Mukherji's cop characters from two previous hit thrillers: Probir Roy Chowdhury, played by Bangla superstar Prosenjit Chatterjee, from *Baishe Shrabon* (2011), and Bijoy Poddar (Anirban Bhattacharya), from *Vinci Da* (2019).

Dawshom Awbotaar emerged from two separate incidents. There was the promise made to Chatterjee about revisiting his foul-mouthed cop Probir, who died in *Baishe Shrabon*. And years back, while preparing a web series adaptation of Arnab Ray's novel *The Mahabharata Murders*, he had in mind a second season about a serial killer who imagines himself as Vishnu's tenth avatar. "There will be cross-referential quirks and hat tips to my earlier films," says Mukherji.

The National Award-winning Bangla director, best known to national audiences for his Hindi films *Begum Jaan* (2017), and *Shabaash Mithu* (2022), is surely India's busiest filmmaker right now. Between this year and the next, he has seven releases lined up. Alongside *Dawshom Awbotaar*, Mukherji has an eight-episode Byomkesh Bakshi mystery *Durgo Rawhosyo*, out on Hoichoi on the same day. "I have a mortal fear of dying before I get to tell all my stories," he says. "I work 18-20 hours a day, all weekends, no holidays. I cannot sit still at home."

His other five projects to be released until 2024-end include the comedy *Oti Uttam*, the Mrinal Sen biopic *Padatik*, season two of *Feludar Goyendagiri*, a film with Bangla superstar Dev, and a Hindi Sherlock Holmes adaptation starring Kay Kay Menon as the sleuth and Ranvir Shorey as his Watson.

When INDIA TODAY caught up with Mukherji, he was dividing time between multiple studios in Kolkata finishing post-production on his October 19 twin releases. "In between, I have to promote my films, finish patchwork shooting and also film a music video," Mukherji says.

His grand plans continue. *Dawshom Awbotaar* is planned as the first film of his cop universe. He hopes to include other hit cop characters from Bangla films. These include Saswata Chatterjee's Animesh Dutta from the *Proloy* series and Ranjit Mallick's cop Shubhankar from the 1984 film *Shatru*.

Mukherji's workaholism, which he calls "manic", had him spending all of 2023 in Mumbai for multiple Hindi releases, which includes the 2023 Zee5 series *Jaanbaaz Hindustan Ke*. This year, Kolkata has been his battleground. "My personal life suffers because of my work," Mukherji says. "I have had breakups because of this." But his wife, Bangladeshi actor and child rights activist Rafiath Rashid Mithila, has been "very understanding", he says. Mithila is based in Dhaka.

Mukherji's fast-paced working method has drawn him, besides box-office success, eager producers in Mumbai and beyond. "That we can roll out films in record time with scant resources is explicitly mentioned to us when we work in Mumbai," Mukherji says. "Our budgets and shooting days are minuscule in Kolkata but we can push with high efficiency because of efficient time management." More hustle culture lessons please, Mr Mukherji. ■

Devarsi Ghosh



ASHISH K VINCENT

"I never expected 2018 to become India's official Oscar entry. I made the film from the experiences of the people who suffered during the floods. I was myself a victim," says Joseph

Q. What made the film such a success?

I thank my crew, cast and God, who made it all happen. I believe that great things happened in my life and my films due to great interventions—maybe through divine or human interventions. Even if I try my level best to produce my level best, things can go wrong. In *2018*, everything clicked to make it an official Oscar entry. With all humility, I just smile.

Q. How are you planning to promote the film for the Oscars?

No idea. I haven't thought about it. There may be a way. If my film has merit, it will find its way to glory. In *2018*, I made a tagline: 'everyone is a hero'. Let India become a hero. ■

with Jeemon Jacob

based on the encounters of people who witnessed the flood. In such an attempt, I may not be able to graphically follow the government interventions, which have limited relevance in my film. I was not making a propaganda film. Instead, I was profiling the great disaster of our land. I feel that such criticism carries no meaning as everyone appreciated the film.